

WEEK 01 — SPRING 2026

PRACTICE IMMANENT CRITIQUE

Research-creation as methodology. What does it mean to think *with* tools rather than *through* them?

DIGM 553/753 — Experimental Digital Media Lab • Darren Woodland Jr.

*"What is your practice thinking right
now?"*

— not what are you making. what is the act of making already thinking?

"Every practice is a mode of thought, already in the act. To dance: a thinking in movement. To paint: a thinking through color. To perceive in the everyday: a thinking of the world's varied ways of affording itself."

— Manning & Massumi, Thought in the Act

To program — a thinking in what? To route audio signals — a thinking in what? To touch a capacitive sensor — a thinking in what?

W01A

RESEARCH-CREATION

as Method

"Making would already be thinking-in-action, and conceptualization a practice in its own right."

THE PREBIFURCATION POINT

Most institutional models treat research and creative practice as *sequential* and *separate*: research produces knowledge, practice illustrates it.

Research-creation is an attempt to name the activity that happens before this split. Where making and thinking are not distinct acts but two registers of the same act, happening simultaneously.

*Manning & Massumi: activity at the **prebifurcation point** — before research and creation diverge into institutional structures that evaluate them by separate criteria.*

INHABITING COMPLICITY

*"An immanent critique engages with new processes more than new products...
The strategy of immanent critique is to inhabit one's complicity and make it
turn — in the sense in which butter 'turns' to curd."*

— Manning & Massumi

We work *within* the university, with commercial tools, toward grades. That is our complicity. Immanent critique means making that complicity productive. We do not wait until we're free of it to begin practice.

DISTINCTIONS TO INTERNALIZE

01

Process, not Product

"An interpenetration of processes rather than a communication of products."
The artifact is the *record* of practice, not the point of it.

02

Conditioning, not Framing

Framing sets rules.
Conditioning brings co-causes into interaction so that something *emerges* that neither cause alone could produce.

03

Enabling Constraints

A limitation that, through interaction, generates emergence rather than restriction. Gravity enables the jump.

THE PRODUCTIVE LIMIT

"In our experience, unconstrained interaction rarely yields worthwhile effects."

— Manning & Massumi

The MPR121 sensor constrains what counts as input. CircuitPython constrains what you can compute. OSC constrains the format of the data.

These are the **material conditions** from which something emerges. We do not aim to eliminate constraints, but turn them from limitative to enabling.

- What in your practice functions as *gravity* — the resistance you push against?
- What would your work look like if that constraint were removed?

W01B

EPISTEMIC TOOLS

Introduction

"Instruments have a life of their own. They do not merely follow theory; often they determine theory, because instruments determine what is possible, and what is possible determines to a large extent what can be thought."

TOOLS ARE NOT NEUTRAL

If making is already a mode of thinking, then the instrument you make *with* is already shaping the kinds of thought that are possible.

Choosing TouchDesigner over Processing, Max/MSP over SuperCollider, a capacitive sensor over a camera. These are **epistemological** decisions just as much as practical or technical.

The choice of instrument is never neutral. It conditions what questions you can ask, what results you can produce, and — eventually — what you consider beautiful, interesting, or true.

HOW INSTRUMENTS RELATE TO THE WORLD

01

Embodiment Relations

You act *through* the instrument. It recedes. You experience the world, not the tool. (The practiced musician and the keys.)

02

Hermeneutic Relations

The instrument produces data you must *interpret*. A spectrograph, a sensor reading, a heat map. The tool mediates by translating.

03

Alterity Relations

The instrument becomes a “quasi-other”. You engage *with* it, not through it. Generative systems, interactive installations.

These modalities are tendencies, not fixed categories. Any practice oscillates between them.

AMPLIFICATION-REDUCTION

Every instrument amplifies certain features of the world and reduces others. No exception.

Instrument	Amplifies / Reduces
Microphone	Pressure-wave events in a frequency range / everything else
MIDI controller	Discrete pitch + velocity events / continuous, gestural sound
MPR121 sensor	Conductivity at 12 points / pressure, texture, temperature, gesture
Your DAW	Timeline-based regions, channels, automation / ?

The danger is not that tools reduce, they must in order to function. The danger is *forgetting* what they reduce.

BLACK BOXES

"The more naturalized the object becomes, the more unquestioning the relationship of the community to it; the more invisible the contingent and historical circumstances of its birth, the more it sinks into the community's routinely forgotten memory."

— Bowker & Star

The tools you're most fluent with are the most dangerous. **Fluency produces blindness.**

The instrument you've used for years is the instrument whose assumptions you've most thoroughly absorbed into your practice without noticing.

- What's the most black-boxed tool in your practice?
- When did you last open it?

COMPUTATIONAL IMPERIALISM

"A computer, then, does not simply have an instrumental use in a given site of practice; the computer is frequently about that site in its very design."

— Philip Agre, *Toward a Critical Technical Practice*

Computers, on top of representing activity, also *restructure* it. A DAW (while used for recording and production), fundamentally restructures music-making around timelines, discrete regions, channels, automation curves.

These are models of music built by engineers with particular assumptions about what music *is*.

THE SPLIT IDENTITY

CRAFT FOOT

Fluency. Building. The practiced hand that reaches for the tool without thinking. The expertise that closes black boxes so you can work fast.

CRITIQUE FOOT

Questioning. Opening. The reflexive attention that re-examines assumptions the craft foot has naturalized. The voice that asks *why this tool, why these defaults*.

The split identity never “resolves”. It is the ongoing condition of critical technical practice, not a phase of it.

W01C – Magnusson

HARDWARE & SOFTWARE

Inventory

"The digital system is material in its body, electric in function, and symbolic in control." — Thor Magnusson

AN EPISTEMIC INVENTORY

Each arrow is a transformation — an amplification-reduction pair.

```
Body / Material World → [touch, vibration, conductance, presence] MPR121 Sensor → [12 threshold
events — everything else disappears] QT Py RP2040 → [CircuitPython — sequential, real-time, no
threads] OSC / UDP → [named address + typed args — prioritizes latency over reliability]
TouchDesigner / Max/MSP → [dataflow model — spatial, parallel, visual] Output / Audience
```

NAMING IS A PHILOSOPHICAL ACT

When designing your OSC namespace, you have to decide what to *call* your data:

Option	Problem
/sensor/capacitive_threshold_event/ch/7	Too technical: reveals the mechanism, hides the body
/presence_of_hand/right/index	Too phenomenological: claims more than the sensor knows
/sensor/touch/7	Intermediation: bridges the technical and the lived

Your first OSC schema is a philosophical document. What you choose to name your data channels reveals what you think the interaction *is*.

W01C – Research Example

DEMO

DO YOUR EPISTEMIC INVENTORY

Pick one tool you already use in your practice. Any tool. Ask:

- What does this tool **amplify**? What becomes easy, visible, measurable?
- What does this tool **reduce**? What disappears, gets rounded off?
- What world does it **assume exists**? What implicit model of activity, body, or material does its design encode?
- **Who** designed those assumptions, and for what context?

This exercise is the foundation of ASN 2 — Critical Technical Journal. It begins this week.

THREE QUESTIONS

to Carry

- What does your tool amplify? What becomes easy, visible, measurable?
- What does your tool reduce? What is systematically missing from what it captures?
- Who designed the reduction? The defaults in your software were chosen by someone with specific assumptions. What were they?

VOCABULARY

RESEARCH-CREATION (VARIOUS)

Activity at the prebifurcation point where making and thinking are co-constitutive, not sequential.

ENABLING CONSTRAINT (MANNING & MASSUMI)

A limitation that, through interaction with other forces, generates emergence rather than just restriction.

AMPLIFICATION-REDUCTION (IHDE)

Every tool amplifies certain features and reduces others. No tool is neutral.

IMMANENT CRITIQUE (MANNING & MASSUMI)

Inhabiting complicity and making it turn; critique from inside the system, not from outside it.

EPISTEMIC TOOL (MAGNUSSON)

An instrument that is a knowledge-making artifact; tools determine what is possible and thus what can be thought.

BLACK BOX (LATOURE)

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